



HERDERS check out an Iranian projectile Wednesday on the outskirts of Qamishli in northeastern Syria.

BADERKHAN AHMAD Associated Press

Stall in rollout of solar to aid needy

California’s program is way behind those of other states, with only 34 projects since 2015.

By BLANCA BEGETT

The tiny town of West Goshen, Calif., was exactly the kind of place that community solar was designed for.

Near Visalia, most of its 500 residents live in mobile homes, where companies won’t install rooftop panels without a solid foundation. And until recently, they used propane for heating and cooking, with price fluctuations in the winter posing hardships for low-income families.

Community solar, in which residents get a discount on their bills for subscribing as a group to small solar arrays nearby, was designed to help low-income residents, apartment dwellers, renters and others who can’t put panels on their own roofs.

Over the last 11 years, New York, Maine, Minnesota, Massachusetts and other states have built thriving community solar programs. But California has built, at most, only 34 projects since 2015, and experts say that’s a generous accounting.

“We’ve had community solar for a dozen years, and it simply has not produced anything of scale and anything of note,” said Derek Chernow, director of Californians for Local, Affordable Solar and Storage, a developer trade group that’s pushing to get a more robust program off the ground. “Projects don’t pencil out.”

The West Goshen residents were among the lucky few, becoming part of a community solar project in 2024.

“It has kind of allowed us to kind of breathe a little bit,” said resident and community solar advocate [See **Solar**, A10]

Hackers trick AI bots to do their dirty work

By Nilesh Christopher

Welcome to the age of AI hacking, in which the right prompts turn amateurs into master hackers.

A group of cybercriminals recently used off-the-shelf artificial intelligence chatbots to steal data on nearly 200 million taxpayers. The bots provided the code and ready-to-execute plans to bypass firewalls.

Although they were explicitly programmed to refuse to help hackers, the bots were duped into abetting the cybercrime.

According to a recent report from Israeli cybersecurity firm Gambit Security, hackers last month used Claude, the chatbot from Anthropic, to steal 150 gigabytes of data from Mexican government agencies.

Claude initially refused to cooperate with the hacking attempts and even denied requests to cover the hackers’ digital tracks, the experts who discovered the breach said. The group pummelled the bot with more than 1,000 prompts to bypass the safeguards and convince Claude they were allowed to test the system for vulnerabilities.

AI companies have been trying to create unbreakable chains on their AI models to restrain them from helping do things such as generating child sexual content or aiding in sourcing and creating weapons. They hire entire teams to try to break their own chatbots before someone else does.

But in this case, hackers continuously prompted [See **AI**, A11]



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

ZAC CHAMBERS teaches his daughter Whitney, 6, to snowboard on Mt. Baldy.

Determined to avoid wipeout

Mt. Baldy Resort fights to stay open amid fierce competition

By JACK DOLAN

For the handful of skiers gliding across a sun-drenched ridge high in the San Gabriel Mountains, the wide expanse of the Inland Empire stretched to the Pacific Ocean nearly two vertical miles below.

Across sparkling water, the rugged spine of Catalina Island graced the horizon.

The view rivaled anything at the posh, world-renowned ski resorts of Lake Tahoe, but this was humble

Mt. Baldy — the familiar local mountain that, for a few precious weeks each year, becomes a downhill skiing destination that holds its own with anything in the American West.

Last week — after the 10,000-foot summit that looms above Los Angeles emerged from storm clouds blanketed in white — was one for the ages.

But in a rapidly warming world, and in an industry dominated by two huge and growing conglomerates that are crushing the competi-

tion, every run feels fleeting.

These days, managing a small ski business is like trying to keep a mom-and-pop general store afloat after Walmart comes to town.

By noon Feb. 25 on Mt. Baldy — a little more than an hour’s drive from downtown L.A. — it was getting pretty hot, and the snow was melting fast.

For a skier racing between towering Jeffrey pines and plummeting through soft, slushy piles of forgiving snow, the hardest part was [See **Mt. Baldy**, A6]

U.S. demands allies cooperate with war effort

Pentagon says it is ramping up attacks on Iran. Devastation spreads across region.

By KEVIN RECTOR AND ANA CEBALLOS

The U.S. war effort against Iran was “accelerating” as American and Israeli forces fought for control of Iranian airspace and pressed farther inland to seek and destroy Iranian missile capabilities, top U.S. officials said Wednesday.

“Four days in, we have only just begun to fight,” said U.S. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth.

“The throttle is coming up,” said Gen. Dan Caine, the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff.

A reported Iranian missile strike at NATO member Turkey — intercepted by the alliance’s defense systems — was not expected to immediately broaden the war theater by triggering a clause requiring other member nations to get involved, Hegseth said.

The White House, however, said President Trump expects full cooperation from European allies in the war effort and had successfully

pressured Spain into such compliance using financial threats, which Spain denied.

At a Wednesday event about tech companies paying to ramp up utility capacity for AI data centers, Trump said that these are “exciting times” and that the U.S. was “doing very well on the war front, to put it mildly” — giving it a score of “15” out of 10 on its war efforts.

Democrats have questioned Trump’s authority to wage war on Iran without explicit congressional approval. However, the Senate on Wednesday afternoon narrowly voted down a resolution that would have required U.S. forces to withdraw from the conflict until such approval is given.

Submarine sinks Iranian warship

Hegseth, striking an unapologetic tone, said Iran’s surviving leaders “don’t know what plays to call” after exhausting initial retaliatory strategies devised before the U.S. assault, while the U.S. is firing on all fronts and racking up wins — including an American submarine recently sinking an Iranian warship with a torpedo in international waters [See **Iran**, A5]

Eyes on L.A. are raising concern

Other cities cut ties with Flock’s license plate readers for fear of federal use of data.

By LIBOR JANY

Santa Cruz tried out the surveillance company Flock Safety for a little over a year before deciding it was time to move on.

Cambridge, Mass., also had enough and tore up its contract in December. Now, some officials in San Diego have begun to have second thoughts of their own.

In recent months, dozens of cities have cut ties with Flock — the nation’s largest provider of automated digital license plate readers — over fears that data the company captures are helping power President Trump’s mass deportation campaign.

The same can’t be said in one particularly surprising place: Los Angeles. Here, Flock still has an eager customer base of local elected officials, police officers, homeowners’ associations and businesses.

Unlike some of its competitors, the Atlanta-based company has not only mar-

keted its plate readers to law enforcement as a vital crime-fighting tool, but also aggressively pitched its product to private citizens, experts say.

“They are tremendous investigative tools,” LAPD spokesman Capt. Michael Bland said.

But for critics, there’s an obvious downside: the potential tracking of law-abiding citizens without a warrant on a scale once thought unimaginable.

“These can be really powerful tools to find someone, and identify them. But when you don’t have a suspect, everyone can be a suspect,” said Hannah Bloch-Wehba, a professor of law at Texas A&M University.

A Flock spokesperson did not respond to multiple requests for comment for this article.

Typically mounted on street poles or atop police cars, plate readers continuously monitor passing vehicles [See **Flock**, A7]

Under scrutiny in Los Angeles

Police Commission is examining the LAPD’s relationship with Flock Safety. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Trump to make pick in Texas race

President says he will soon endorse Ken Paxton or John Cornyn in the GOP Senate runoff. **NATION**, A4

A love story high above Big Bear

The closely watched fertility saga of bald eagle couple Jackie and Shadow stretches back years. **SCIENCE**, A8

Hoping for a lift from ‘Hoppers’

Animated film opening this week is Pixar’s latest try to break through at theaters with an original story. **BUSINESS**, A9

Weather

Mostly sunny; warm. L.A. Basin: 79/53. **B6**

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KAYLA BARTKOWSKI L.A. Times
DR. MARY Marfisee leads the mobile clinic.

Mammograms at Skid Row clinic

A joint effort by City of Hope, UCLA and Union Rescue Mission offers the cancer screening to women. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

How state’s ICE mask ban got waylaid

A concession to gain Newsom’s support opened the door to a Trump legal victory.

By SONJA SHARP

The judge was perplexed. “Why were state law enforcement officers excluded?” U.S. District Judge Christina A. Snyder wanted

to know.

The judge pressed California Deputy Atty. Gen. Cameron Bell to explain the thinking behind a pair of trailblazing new laws meant to unmask the federal immigration agents patrolling Golden State streets and compel them to identify themselves.

One of the laws required all law enforcement operating in the state to visibly display identification while

on duty, with narrow exclusions for plainclothes, undercover and SWAT details. It applied to everyone else, including U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers.

But the other law, a ban on masks worn by on-duty law enforcement officers, applied only to local cops and federal agents, with a broad exemption for the California Highway Patrol and other state peace officers.

Snyder wanted to know: Why were the laws different?

She never got an answer. Bell said she couldn’t comment on the actions of the Legislature.

In the halls of the statehouse last year, Sen. Scott Wiener’s (D-San Francisco) No Secret Police Act and Sen. Sasha Renée Pérez’s (D-Alhambra) No Vigilantes Act were referred to as “legislative twins,” a nod to their [See **Masks**, A7]